PROJECT DOCUMENT

# BIOMASS ENERGY & AI

Reforesting in Mitsue — Ecology · Energy · Digital Infrastructure

v4.0 · 2026-08-14 · Rob Oudendijk

> **"The forest our ancestors planted — the power that sustains the village they built"**

*A 25-year initiative to revitalise the former Sugano Elementary School and the forest that surrounds it*

## What the Project Is

Transforms the **former Sugano Elementary School (Mitsue Taiken Koryukan)** (leading candidate site, final choice confirmed in Phase 1) and the aging cedar forest above it into a living model of rural self-sufficiency. Three elements work together:

- **Forest restoration** — Replacing aging sugi monoculture with native species. Thinnings yield biomass fuel; native broadleaf trees feed deer/boar/bear, reducing crop damage
- **Biomass CHP energy** — Sugi thinnings fuel a combined heat & power system (electricity + heat), complemented by solar and EV charging, with backup during outages
- **Sustainable AI data center** — Small, efficient digital facility in the former school or a disused factory, powered entirely by local energy — new infrastructure and jobs

These are not three separate ideas — each one makes the others possible.

## The Problems This Project Solves

| Challenge | How the Project Responds |
|---|---|
| Former school/factories vacant | Repurposed as data center & community anchor (site confirmed Phase 1) |
| Cedar monoculture, ecologically depleted | Systematic conversion to native mixed forest |
| Grid dependency, no local power | Biomass CHP from sugi thinnings as primary supply, solar/EV as complement |
| Shrinking population, no local jobs | **Roughly doubling the forestry cooperative crew** + data center/energy/maintenance roles |
| Blackouts, wildlife crop damage | On-site biomass power keeps key facilities running; restored forest keeps wildlife in the woods |

## Who Is Behind It

**Rob Oudendijk** — Dutch electrical engineer, resident of Mitsue since 2012, core hardware developer for Safecast.

**Advisors:** Ray Ozzie (Blues) · San Poisson · Takuo Dome (Prof. Emeritus, Osaka University) · Evin Zoet / Yoshiko Zoet-Suzuki (Transom)

A dedicated **non-profit** is being established with local residents, village leadership, forestry professionals, and academic partners.

## Benefits Arrive Well Before Year 25

| Timeline | Milestone |
|---|---|

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|---|---|
| Year 1 | Site (school/unused factory) activated; international media visibility |
| Year 2 | Landowners begin receiving cedar harvest income |
| Year 3–4 | EV charging stations operational |
| Year 4–5 | Data center operational; local jobs begin |
| Year 5–10 | Data revenue reinvested into village and forest programmes |
| Year 25 | Native forest established; model published worldwide |

## Financing — Seeking Seed Money

**No funding is secured yet.** The immediate need is **seed money** to move Phase 0/1 forward (feasibility studies, legal incorporation, early outreach). Once in place, the plan stacks complementary sources: 林野庁 forestry grants · METI/NEDO rural energy grants · village 2/3–3/4 renewable-energy subsidy · FIT/FIP · J-Credit · data center revenue · impact investment.

## Current Status

The project is in **Phase 0** — community consultation, feasibility study, non-profit formation. No major commitments have been made. This is the moment to ask questions, raise concerns, and shape what comes next.

## How to Get Involved

- **Residents & landowners** — Join the consultation process
- **Foresters & new residents** — Paid roles as the crew doubles (relocation support available)
- **Investors & philanthropists** — Phase 0 seed money
- **Professionals & researchers** — Feasibility input, technical review, collaboration

More at [mitsue.it/join](mitsue.it/join)

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> *"If it works here, it can work elsewhere."*

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